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July 8, 2026

Asha Reed, City Clerk
1 Frank H. Ogawa Plaza
Oakland, CA 94612

RE: Financial Analysis of the Mayor's Charter Reform Ballot Measure

Dear City Clerk Reed:

I am pleased to submit the following impartial financial analysis of the Mayor's Charter Reform ballot measure.

The Office of the City Auditor prepared this analysis in accordance with Municipal Code Section 3.08.210, which tasks the Office of the City Auditor with preparing an impartial financial analysis of each measure qualifying for placement on a City ballot.

If you have any questions, please contact Stephanie Noble Wilson, Assistant City Auditor.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "MCHouston".

Michael C. Houston, MPP, CIA
City Auditor

THE CITY AUDITOR’S IMPARTIAL FINANCIAL ANALYSIS OF MEASURE__

Summary of Financial Impact

This ballot measure proposes to amend the City Charter by tasking the Public Ethics Commission with setting the salaries for the Mayor and Councilmembers every two years beginning in 2027.

In addition, the ballot measure proposes the establishment of an Independent Budget and Legislative Analyst Office to provide fiscal, policy, and feasibility analysis for the City Council.

Financial Analysis

The Public Ethics Commission would set the salaries of the Mayor and the Councilmembers considering the highest paid professional fulltime employees in the respective offices of the Mayor and City Council, as well as similar fulltime positions in comparable California cities and counties chosen by the Public Ethics Commission. While specific salary increases would depend on the Public Ethics Commission’s proposals, our Office estimates an increase of \$36,000 to \$108,000 in salary and benefits per Councilmember, resulting in an increase of \$288,000 to \$867,000 for the entire City Council in the first year.

To estimate total personnel costs arising from the measure if passed, we included benefits in addition to base salaries. We referenced the methodology of the Public Ethics Commission to calculate ranges based on other Bay Area and California jurisdictions and highest paid employees of the offices of the Mayor and City Council for FY 2025-26. We also considered the salaries of other City department heads but omitted them from our final analysis due to lack of comparability. Based on these factors, we do not estimate a significant increase in the Mayor’s salary and benefits.

Using the salaries of similar positions in the City of Oakland, the Independent Budget and Legislative Analyst Office would cost approximately \$1.7 to \$1.8 million in staffing and overhead. We reviewed other jurisdictions to estimate staffing to include one independent budget and legislative analyst, three analysts, and one administrative assistant.

We estimate that if this ballot measure passes, the overall cost to the City ranges from \$2.0 million to \$2.6 million for the first year, with ongoing costs subject to inflation.

This analysis is based on the best information available at this time.

MICHAEL C. HOUSTON
City Auditor